

Tough pill to swallow: According to India's chairman of selectors, Ajit Agarkar, Rinku Singh's exclusion was the "toughest" decision the selectors had to make while picking the T20 World Cup squad. K.R. DEEPAK

T20Is TAKE BACKSEAT AS LEAGUES SERVE AS WARMUPS FOR WORLD CUP SELECTION

India and South Africa have **increasingly turned** to their franchise T20 leagues when making national selection calls.

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With the Indian Premier League (IPL) capturing the attention of fans, experts, and selectors for over two months, the lucrative extravaganza seems to have become the primary testing ground for T20 World Cup selection, even as

international matches in the shortest format take a backseat.

India's last international assignment was a three-match T20I series against Afghanistan in January at home that saw the return of Rohit Sharma as captain and Virat Kohli to the fold in the shortest format. The duo had not featured in a single T20I since India's defeat in the semifinal of the T20 World Cup in November

2022, following which it looked like the national team was eyeing a major overhaul, with Hardik Pandya assuming the reins.

Still, India only played 20 T20Is in the 12 months leading to this year's T20 World Cup and 28 since the last global tournament. Contrastingly, in 2022, India had featured in 40 matches in the year leading to the T20 World Cup and had played 35